

2026 PUBLIC AND CHARTER
FLAG FOOTBALL RULEBOOK

GENERAL

- All players MUST be in grades 5-8th and enrolled at your school. No exceptions. Any team having players outside of these grade levels and not enrolled at your school will forfeit the playoffs and potentially be removed from the league.
- Each team is allowed to have up to 11 players on the field at all times.
- **There must be 4 girls during every play of the game.** If a team does not have enough girls to fill that requirement, that team shall then play short. (ex: if there are 0 girls then a team will only have 7 boys on offense and defense, if a team is short 1 girl then that team will have to play the 3 girls they have the entire game and will have to play with 10 on offense and defense. A team may play with more than 4 girls.
- The home team must have a rope that the defensive and offensive line lines up behind. The rope must be a heavy duty rope that is visible. The rope must be **6ft long/ 2 yards long**
- 1st down every 10 yards: HOME team should have this marked clearly visible on the sidelines

CHANGE OF POSSESSION

- Every new possession of series will start at the 10 yard line after opposing team scores. There are no kick-offs.

PUNTING

- Should any OFFENSE choose to punt, the ball will be turned over to the other team's 10 yard (if offense is stopped at 4th down w/o punting, opposing team will start from that spot).
- Clock stops when a punt is declared inside of 2 minute warnings. Time resumes once the next play is snapped.

COIN TOSS

- A coin toss shall begin each game. The captain/coach winning the toss shall choose one of the following options:
 1. Offense
 2. Defense
 3. Designate which goal his team will defend.
 4. Defer choice to the second half.
- Loser of the coin toss shall make a choice of the remaining options.

- Before the start of the second half, the choice of options shall be reversed.

LIVE BALL AND DEAD BALL

Live Ball

- **SNAP** - The center must snap the ball with a rapid and continuous motion between his legs or from the side to a player in the backfield (not on the Line of Scrimmage) and the ball must completely leave his hands. Illegal result is a False Start penalty
- The ball is live at the snap and remains live until the Official whistles the ball dead.
- **One foot inbounds for Legal Catch:** A player who gains possession in the air is considered in-bounds as long as one foot comes down in the field of play.
- **Imitating Offensive Signals** – The defense may not imitate the offensive team's signals by trying to confuse the offensive players while the Quarterback is calling out signals to start the play. This will result in an **unsportsmanlike conduct penalty**

DEAD BALL

- The ball is ruled dead when:
 1. A snap to a Quarterback hits the ground.
 2. A fumble hits the ground (no fumble recoveries allowed).
 3. A ball carrier's knee touches the ground
 4. A ball carrier steps out of bounds
 5. A ball carrier's flags are legally removed
NOTE: If a ball carrier's flags fall off inadvertently, play shall revert to a one hand touch between the shoulder and knees.
 6. If no flags are worn at the time of the snap, play reverts to a one hand touch. *Rare occasion where defense doesn't have time because offense runs a hurry up play and defense gains possession*
PENALTY: failure to wear proper equipment
 7. A touchdown, point after or safety is scored.
 8. Any Official can whistle the play dead.
 9. Substitutions may be made on any dead ball.

- The Official will indicate the Neutral Zone and Line of Scrimmage. It is an automatic dead ball foul if any player on offense or defense enter the Neutral Zone. In regards to the Neutral Zone, the Official may give both teams a courtesy Neutral Zone notification to allow their players to move back behind the Line of Scrimmage.

NOTE:

1. **There are no fumbles.** The ball is spotted where the ball hit the ground. NOTE: The ball will be spotted where the ball carrier lost the ball if it is fumbled forward.
2. The ball will be spotted wherever the ball was at the time of a flag pull or player was down.

EQUIPMENT

- ROPE: 2 yard Rope for the line of scrimmage. The rope must be a heavy duty rope that is visible. The rope must be 6ft long/ 2 yards long.
- FLAGS: Flags must be on the players hips and free from obstruction. Players must be wearing TRIPLE THREAT flag belts that have 3 flags on them. 2 flags on the side and 1 flag in the back. These are 1-piece belts with NO velcro. Example: [Triple Threat Belts](#).
- JERSEYS: All players MUST have shirts/jerseys tucked in the pants or shorts
- SHOES: NO metal cleats. Cleats are allowed but they must be rubber. Tennis shoes are permitted.
- BALL SIZE: Intermediate, Junior, and regulation are permitted
- NO JEWELRY: Players must remove all watches, earrings, necklaces, or any other jewelry that officials deem hazardous.
- OPTIONAL PROTECTIVE WEAR: Players may wear mouthguards and/or padded helmets. All protective wear must be approved by all referees prior to game time.

TIMING, HALFTIME, AND TIMEOUTS

- Each game will be 40 minutes long; 20 minutes per half
 - **1st half:** Clock ONLY stops for timeouts and change of possession inside (ex: punt, turnover on downs, interception, score).
 - **Two Minute Warning (2nd Half Only)** – When there are 2 minutes left in the 2nd half, the game clock shall stop for incomplete passes, out-of-bounds, time outs, scores , change of possessions, penalties and first downs (clock starts on the snap).
- The game clock will **NOT** stop for a time-out, **EXCEPT** within the last 2 minutes of each half.
- There will be a 5 minute half time unless there isn't enough time (i.e game starts late)
- 30 seconds will be given to each offense to huddle for play calling and snapping the ball. 30 Seconds play clock starts once the ball is placed at the spot of the previous play. (penalty: loss of 5 yards)
- Each team will have 2 timeouts total per half (30 seconds per timeout)
 - Once the 30 second timeout runs out, the offense's 30 second game clock will begin.
- The game clock will stop if a team **PUNTS** the football within the last 2 minutes of each half.
- In the event of an injury, the clock will stop then restart when the injured player is removed from the field of play.

Ending the Game:

- 1) The game may not end with a penalty unless it is declined.
- 2) Penalties by the offense that include a loss of down with time expired in either half (i.e., there is no time on the clock) will not extend the half or game.
- 3) Offsetting penalties will not extend the half or game.

REFEREES / ON FIELD HELPERS

- ~~Offensive coach and Defensive coach will become referees after they give their plays to their players on the field.~~
 - ~~— Offensive coach will referee 5 yards behind the RB~~
 - ~~— Defensive coach will referee 5 yards behind the safety.~~
- ~~Home and Away team must provide 1 sideline referee. (Additionally they assist with play clock, marking of ball and rope, etc)~~
- Home team will provide an additional helper (non-referee) to help with the 10-yard marker/game clock/etc.

OFFENSE

- There can be as many receivers on the line as possible.
- Running plays are acceptable as well as half-back formations
- Only 1 forward pass per play
- Players who are blocking must at all time block with OPEN PALMS, NO CLOSED HANDS. NO BODY BLOWS OR ELBOWS SHOULD BE THROWN! Blocking must occur from the shoulders down. 10 yard penalty and loss of a down.
- Illegal block: A block in the back occurs when a player initiates contact with an opponent from behind
- FLAG BELTS must be visible at ALL times (SHIRTS MUST be tucked in; after first verbal warning, penalty: 5 yards, repeat down) *NOTE*: No verbal warning if person has ball during play.
- QB has to be in shotgun at all times. (1 yard minimum behind line of scrimmage). 5 yard penalty, repeat down.
- QB can run with ball if he/she chooses to but must run outside of the guards. 5 yard penalty, repeat down.
- Offense must run the ball outside of the guards once inside the 5 yard line.
- All players are eligible to receive a pass unless they have stepped out-of-bounds of their own accord.
- No limit on blockers

- A pass is completed when an offensive player simultaneously places at least one foot inbounds and momentarily maintains possession of the ball.
- Simultaneous catches between a defensive and offensive player go to the offense.

Motion -

A. Offensive players must come to a complete stop for 1 second before the ball is snapped unless he is the only player in motion.

1. One player at a time may go in motion at the Snap behind and parallel to the Line of scrimmage.
2. No motion is allowed towards the Line of Scrimmage.

B. Movement by a player who is set or a player who runs toward the Line of Scrimmage while in motion is considered a false start.

DEFENSE

- Should any play fall in the safety zone, defense get 2pts and the ball is turned over to start at the awarded team's 10 yard line.
- Interceptions by defense players can try to return for a touchdown
- The Defensive line will start behind the 2 yard rope.
- No limit on rushers
- Defense MUST have shirts tucked in (first offense is verbal warning, second warning will be loss of 5 yards repeat down)
- Defense must try to go around the offensive line.
- Initial contact with no attempt at slowing down or going around other player - 10 yards
- Defense should NOT have closed fists while trying to get past the offensive line.
- If a player loses their flag belt legally or illegally during a down and gains possession of a live ball, that player is considered down if they are touched with one hand by a defender between the shoulders and the knees.
- Players must have the ball before their flag can legally be pulled.

FLAG PULLING

- **De-Flagging:** De-flagging is the legal removal of a flag from an opponent in possession of the ball. Pushing, striking, holding, slapping or tripping when attempting to pull a flag is not permitted. Defensive players may leave their feet to pull a flag. Offensive players are not permitted to protect or guard their flags.

- A. A legal flag pull takes place when the ball carrier is in full possession of the ball. It's illegal for a defender to intentionally* pull a flag from an offensive player who doesn't have the ball. The infraction is considered a

personal foul with a 10-yard penalty and automatic first down from where the runner was down by touch.

*Note- If there was a fake handoff or other form of deception, then this penalty is void.

- B. If a flag is removed illegally, play should continue with the option of the penalty or the play.
- C. Defenders can dive to pull flags but cannot tackle, hold or run through the ball carrier when pulling flags.
- D. It is illegal to attempt to strip or pull the ball from the ball carrier's possession at any time.
- E. If a player's flag inadvertently fall off during the play, the de-flagging reverts to a one hand touch of the runner between the shoulder and the knees.
- F. A defensive player may not intentionally pull the flags off a player who is not in possession of the ball.
- G. Tampering with the flag in any way to gain an advantage including, tying the flag, cutting the flag, using foreign materials or other such acts are illegal.
- H. Flag guarding is an attempt by the ball carrier to obstruct the defender's access to the flags by stiff arming, dropping the head, hand, arm or shoulder, or intentionally covering the flags with the football jersey.

Unsportsmanlike conduct:

- If the referee witnesses any acts of intentional tackling, elbowing, cheap shots or any unsportsmanlike act, the game will be stopped and the player will be ejected from the game. The decision is made at the Referee's discretion. No appeals will be considered.

FOUL PLAY WILL NOT BE TOLERATED!

- Offensive or confrontational language is illegal. Officials have the right to determine offensive language. If offensive or confrontational language occurs, the Referee will give a warning. If it continues, the player or players will be ejected from the game.
- Players may not physically or verbally abuse any opponent, coach or Official.
- Ball carriers MUST make an effort to avoid defenders with an established position.
- Defender are not allowed to run through the ball carrier when pulling flags.
- **Team/Players leaving the bench area during a fight:**

- If either team leaves the bench during a fight, the game will immediately be forfeited.
- Any player that comes off the sideline during a fight will be ejected and sit out the next

game.

PENALTIES

- Delay of game: 5 yards, repeat down *Clock will stop or continue at opposing teams request with 2 or less minutes remaining*
- Too many players on the field: 5 yards, repeat down
- False Start: 5 yards and repeat down
- Encroachment 5 yard penalty; crossing the 2 yard rope before ball is hiked, repeat down
- Offense offsides: 5 yards and repeat down
- Offense holding: 10 yards and repeat down
- Illegal blocking: 10 yard penalty, repeat down.
- FLAG BELTS not visible: no play, 5 yards, repeat down
- QB not at the 1 yard minimum behind line of scrimmage to take shotgun snap. 5 yard penalty, repeat down.
- QB run inside of the guards or RB inside of 5 yardline. 5 yard penalty, repeat down.
- Illegal forward pass: 5 yards, repeat down
- Offense must run the ball outside of the guards once inside the 5 yard line.
- Flag Guard/Stiff Arm: 5 yards from the spot of foul, loss of down.
 - Flag guarding is the act of a ball carrier denying a defender the opportunity to capture their flag in any physical way.
 - Examples of flag guarding: stiff arming, pinning the flag with arms/ball, swatting, using the ball as a stiff arm, flailing arms across flags, etc
- Personal/Unsportsmanlike Fouls: 15 yard penalty and automatic first down
 - Roughing the passer: Players rushing the Quarterback may attempt to block a pass, however, NO contact can be made with the Quarterback in any way except an attempted flag pull. Blocking the pass or attempting to block the pass and then making contact with the passer will result in a **roughing the Passer penalty**. Players must go for the Quarterback's flag. Penalty will not be enforced if the quarterback initiates contact with defensive player while in the general area (not attempting to make contact with ball or quarterback)
 - Tackling
 - Defender not attempting to go around blocker
 - Hands to face
 - Stripping ball
 - Punching of any kind
 - Confrontational language toward another player, referee or coach
 - Intentionally* pull a flag from an offensive player who doesn't have the ball
- Offensive pass interference: 10 yard penalty, repeat down

- Includes illegal blocking/screening/picking downfield (past 2 yards) before and during throw
- Whether a pass is catchable or uncatchable has no bearing on pass interference.
- Defensive pass interference/holding: 10 yard penalty, repeat down.
 - Whether a pass is catchable or uncatchable has no bearing on pass interference.
- NO JAMMING: 5 yard penalty, repeat down
- Player running with the ball can't run through a defensive player, they must make attempt at going around the defensive player who has established a stationary position: 10 yards from spot of foul with loss of down
- Ball carrier can't dive head first with the ball: 10 yard penalty from spot of foul with loss of down
- Pushing out on the sidelines is not permitted unless the defense was making a fair, legal, and reasonable attempt to pull the ball carrier's flags, i.e. the defender's hands were aimed low at the ball carrier's hips and flags and not high up on the body.: 10 yards from the spot of foul.
- Defensive player mimicking the offensive teams play cadence: 10 yards penalty, repeat down.

Penalty NOTES:

- Games may not end on a defensive penalty unless the offense declines it.
- There are no "Free Plays" - If penalty occurs BEFORE the snap, the play shall not occur.
- Once the ball has been snapped, No penalty stops a live play.
- Penalties will be assessed half the distance to the goal yardage when the penalty yardage is more than half the distance to the goal.
- Flagrant contact fouls will not be tolerated. Offending player(s) will be ejected from that game and sit out the next game
- If a defensive player physically contains, tackles, or attempts to tackle the ball carrier (e.g., bear hugs, holds, wrestles with, obstructs, pushes the ball carrier out-of-bounds, tackles, or attempts to tackle, etc.) without making a clear, legal attempt to pull the ball carrier's flag, the offensive team results in a score awarded if the foul occurred inside the final line-zone-to-gain or the covering official reasonably believes the foul is the only thing that prevented the ball carrier from scoring. (Teaching point: Play the flag not the ball carrier's body or ball as in traditional tackle football).
- Whether or not a ball is tipped or touched in the air has no bearing on the play as it applies to fouls anywhere on the field (roughing, pass interference, personal fouls, illegal contact, etc.).

OVERTIME FOR PLAYOFFS (NO OVERTIME FOR REGULAR SEASON)

- During Playoffs; if the game ends in a tie, then both offenses will get the ball to try and score. The home team will get to choose to either receive the ball or to defend. During the championship game, a coin toss will decide who goes first. The ball will start

at the 20 yard line going in from the offenses endzone. If the score is still tied after both teams' offensive turns, then the game continues until one offense cannot score. If a teams offense gets intercepted and the defense scores a TD then the game is over. If an offense is intercepted, but the defense does not score and that teams offense cannot score then gameplay will continue until a team does score.

- Each team is awarded 1 timeout per overtime period

POINTS

- Offensive touchdown = 6 pts
- Interception for touchdown = 6 pts
- After TD teams can either take a free point or attempt a 2 pt. conversion from the 10 yard line.
- Safety = 2 pts

FIELD DIMENSIONS

*****FIELDS WILL BE SET UP IN 80 X 40 yards

20 yards for endzones (10 yards each)

60 yards for playing

80 yards total

40 yards wide

-G-----

TOUCHDOWN ZONE

-G-----

-10-----

-20-----

-30-----

-20-----

-10-----

-G-----

TOUCHDOWN ZONE

-G-----